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Lesson 6. Understanding Disciple-Making Movement

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Lesson 6. Understanding Disciple-Making Movement

I. INTRODUCTION TO DISCIPLE-MAKING MOVEMENTS (DMM)

Disciple-Making Movements (DMM) are dynamic spiritual movements characterized by rapid multiplication of disciples who actively make other disciples. At its core, a DMM is a spiritual awakening where disciples intentionally share the Gospel, train new believers, and establish churches that replicate this process rapidly and organically. Historically and biblically, these movements align with the principles demonstrated by the early church as recorded in Acts.

II. HISTORICAL AND BIBLICAL OVERVIEW

A. Early Church Model (Acts 2, Acts 19)

- B. The birth of the early church, as described in Acts, sets a clear precedent for modern Disciple-Making Movements.
- C. The Pentecost event resulted in the conversion of three thousand souls who immediately began to live in a committed community, engaging daily in teaching, fellowship, the breaking of bread, and prayer (Acts 2:42-47).
- D. The immediate and consistent multiplication of disciples was marked by genuine community, obedience-based discipleship, radical generosity, and continuous outreach.
- E. Paul's ministry in Ephesus demonstrated a rapid spread of the Gospel throughout the region.
- F. Within two years, "all the residents of Asia heard the word of the Lord, both Jews and Greeks" (Acts 19:10).
- G. Paul trained local leaders who took responsibility for disciple-making, creating sustainable and multiplying churches that transformed entire regions.

III. PAUL'S MULTIPLICATION STRATEGY (2 TIMOTHY 2:2)

- A. Paul's explicit instruction to Timothy encapsulates the core strategy behind DMMs:

- B. “And what you have heard from me in the presence of many witnesses entrust to faithful men who will be able to teach others also.” (2 Timothy 2:2)
- C. The principle of multiplication is fundamental:
- D. Discipleship moves beyond individual spiritual growth to intentional replication through training faithful disciples who can then train others.
- E. Paul’s model established four generations of discipleship, demonstrating sustainability and exponential growth.

IV. ESSENTIAL COMPONENTS OF DISCIPLE-MAKING MOVEMENTS

A. Obedience-Based Discipleship

- Obedience-based discipleship emphasizes practical application over theoretical knowledge.
 - Jesus Himself underscores obedience in Matthew 28:19-20 by instructing disciples not merely to teach knowledge, but to “teach them to observe all that I have commanded you.”
 - Within DMMs, disciples are trained to immediately obey and implement biblical teachings into their lives. This approach fosters genuine transformation and encourages rapid spiritual maturity.

B. Person of Peace Principle

DMMs consistently utilize the “Person of Peace” concept derived from Luke 10:5-6. These individuals are community influencers receptive to the Gospel who then become instrumental in establishing new groups of believers. Identifying and training persons of peace significantly accelerates the multiplication process.

C. Simple, Reproducible Methods

Disciple-Making Movements rely on simple, reproducible tools that can be easily passed from person to person without dependence on extensive resources or advanced training. Practices such as Discovery Bible Study (DBS), the 3/3rds meeting format, and relational evangelism equip ordinary believers to become active disciple-makers, regardless of literacy levels or socioeconomic status.

D. Rapid Multiplication and Generational Growth

One defining feature of DMMs is their emphasis on rapid generational multiplication. Rather than slow and linear growth through addition, DMMs experience exponential growth as each disciple actively engages in making

multiple new disciples who, in turn, replicate the process. This multiplication creates generations of believers who continue expanding the movement indefinitely.

V. CASE EXAMPLES

A. South Asia Movement

One significant DMM occurred in South Asia in Nepal. This movement began with a vision to target each unreached and unengaged people group. Beginning with a great commission vision event in the capital city, Kathmandu, the Nepali leaders began to build trust with one another and to think and work across denominational boundaries. Foreign mission organizations also banded together in unity to reduce any fears of competition. Both the Nepali and Western organizations moved slowly and carefully to strengthen relationships. After the first couple of gatherings and trainings, the movement began modestly but rapidly expanded. Initial teams emphasized prayer, fasting, obedience-based teaching, and training local leaders. As the movement grew further into the remote areas of the Himalayan mountains, the coalition of leaders began to discover more tribes and villages that had never heard the Gospel, thus the need and project expanded beyond the original scope. Over a decade, thousands of churches were planted in village homes, transforming entire regions and having a profound impact on local culture. The DMM continues today, reaching further, discipling more, and advancing the Kingdom.

B. East Africa Movement

In southern Africa in the nation of Zambia, a disciple-making approach grounded in obedience-based discipleship, evangelism, and intentional multiplication quickly took root. Training took place in conjunction of the course of one week with an intense focus on personal evangelism. Zambia has a large Christian population and is estimated to have over 85% of its population as followers of Jesus. However, the church has become complacent in reaching unreached villages and remote areas. The Christian population is primarily concentrated in cities and easily accessible villages. Training included a practical outreach in which all attendees were taken to the local market and then sent out to share their faith. Each trainee was not allowed to carry a phone but was permitted to carry a Bible. For several hours, men and women shared their faith, and hundreds received Jesus as their Lord and Savior. From this practical training and experience, over 50 new house churches were planted within several weeks. The initial complacency and resistance of the trainees

gave way to a broad movement of disciples, who planted numerous churches now born with a heart for evangelism. Local believers took full responsibility, ensuring the movement's sustainability and continued growth. Now the house churches are working through obedience-based discipleship and targeting further unreached villages.

VI. CONCLUSION

Disciple-Making Movements represent a strategic return to biblical methods of evangelism, discipleship, and church planting. Grounded in simplicity, obedience, and multiplication, DMMs have consistently proven effective in diverse cultural contexts globally. By understanding and embracing the core components and biblical foundations of DMM, contemporary disciples can effectively engage communities and catalyze movements capable of transforming regions and nations with the power of the Gospel.

This lesson was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org).

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